🌾 Ag Words & Whatcom Farms: Reading

Ag Science 1 · Unit 1 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with Ag Literacy: Ag Terms (Top 50), Farming for Life, WA Farm Bureau statistics, Whatcom Ag Businesses, Tour de Whatcom

Name: _____

Agriculture Close to Home

Agriculture is the science and practice of growing crops and raising animals for food, fiber and other products. Agribusiness includes the farming, processing and selling of those products, from a feed store to a veterinarian. Organic farms grow food without synthetic pesticides or fertilizers.

Healthy farms start with healthy soil. Topsoil is the top layer, where most roots grow, and erosion wears it away. Farmers protect it with crop rotation, planting different crops in turns. Legumes like beans and peas add nitrogen to the soil. Farmers also use fertilizer and compost to feed plants, pesticides to control pests and herbicides to control weeds.

Technology changes farming. A combine harvests, threshes and cleans grain in one pass. Precision agriculture uses GPS, drones and sensors. Hydroponics grows plants in nutrient water with no soil.

Washington grows about 300 crops, second only to California in variety. Agriculture adds about $51 billion to the state's economy and supports more than 164,000 jobs. In 2016 the top five products were apples, milk, potatoes, cattle and wheat. Washington exports (sells to other countries) apples, wheat and more, and imports foods like coffee and bananas.

Whatcom County leads the state in red raspberries, grows many blueberries, is a top dairy county, and grows seed potatoes for growers across the West. Whatcom has about 1,582 farms, and most are small. Once farmland is built on, it rarely comes back, so protecting it matters for food, clean water and salmon habitat.

Check your reading

1. What is the difference between a crop and livestock?

2. Name two crops or products Whatcom County is known for.

3. What is an export?